writing about the Jallianwala Bagh Massacre in 1919, he lamented, ‘Every day that I have been working side by side with my Indian fellow-workers, the deep sense of the wrong done has come home to me, and each act has been in very truth an act of penance, of atonement, an act of reparation for my country.’[3]

In fact, in a much-forgotten masterpiece, Edward Thompson, as early as 1925 in his aptly named *The Other Side of the Medal* wrote in the preface that his book ‘will change the attitude of every Englishman who reads it to the end’, pointing out that ‘if that belief is justified, then I have no choice but to trust to the magnanimity of my own people . . .’ in what he described as a work which ‘has long been suppressed’.[4] This is because for him ‘[t]he East India Company was the successor of the Mughal Empire, and it wrought after its ways. Instead of impaling and flaying alive, it put to death in other fashion; under both rules, districts where rebellion had taken place were depopulated and pillaged’.[5] Significantly, he did not regard British colonial brutality as being exceptional at all. Referring for example to what is popularly known as the Indian Mutiny of 1857, he remarked, ‘It is our glorification of the Mutiny that is exceptional, not its brutality.’[6]

With respect to the Amritsar Massacre of 1919, he wrote, ‘It is impossible to overestimate the harm by the hysterical way in which the European community rushed to the defence of the Punjab repressions, and especially Jallianwalla.’[7] For this reason, Edward Thompson ends his highly controversial work with the observation, ‘There is no commoner word on Indian lips today than *atonement.* England, they say, has never made atonement; and she must do it before we can be friends. The word in their minds is the Sanskrit word *prayaschitta,* usually translated *atonement*; but its meaning is rather *a gesture*.’ In fact, he even suggests at the time, ‘It is not larger measures of self-government for which they are longing, it is the magnanimous gesture of a great nation, so great that it can afford to admit mistake and wrong-doing, and is too proud to distort facts.’[8] With the passage of nearly a hundred years, since when Thompson penned these words, it is even more important today that the facts are not distorted, even as the passage of time makes the risks manifestly greater, for as Thompson